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How AI Is Affecting Human Agency

Ethnographic findings from the US, Singapore, & Germany

TL;DR

- In the AI era, **feelings of agency are becoming the core driver of people's tech use**. People continue to use AI even when it fails them or makes mistakes because it offers a powerful boost to their feelings of agency.
- While the AI industry is largely focused on improving people's ability to get things done more effectively, **we found that people experience 4 other kinds of agency with AI**. AI has the capacity to both support and undermine each kind.
- AI use also **impacts different people's agency differently depending on their incoming self-confidence and perceived stability** in the world around them.
- Designing tech in a way that builds human agency can improve users' confidence in themselves and their ability to navigate the world, which may **activate a virtuous cycle of agency** gains that are sustained and substantial, not short-term or illusory.

These insights are from our
ethnographic research

60 advanced AI users

100+ hours of interviews

3 countries

1) The 5 Types of Agency

What is 'agency'?

Our participants experienced agency as the feeling of greater possibilities & the ability to take steps towards realizing them.

How is this novel?

'Agency' is often conflated with control – but in talking to advanced AI users, we discovered that agency is a much richer experience of capability.

This definition focuses on felt (or perceived) agency, and expands beyond control to emphasize human capability and growth.

Across our small but varied sample, we identified **5 Types of Agency** affected and activated by AI use. **AI is capable of both supporting and undermining each type of agency.**

When rolling out new AI models and products, the industry tends to focus predominantly on **instrumental agency** — **there is a big opportunity to strengthen the other four.**

Type of agency	How AI supports	How AI undermines
 Instrumental agency: The ability to get things done effectively — solving problems, moving tasks forward, achieving outcomes	• Helping people start and finish tasks • Reducing information overwhelm with a starting point	• Getting stuck in gear • Encouraging skill atrophy through overreliance
 Cognitive agency: The ability to think clearly, form opinions, and organize thoughts	• Helping organize & develop ideas • Providing access to focused dialogue • Finding perspectives on a new topic	• Being endlessly affirming • Influencing or persuading users • Reducing users' ability to think laterally & independently
 Affective agency: The ability to feel, navigate, name, & manage varied emotional states	• Helping name & make sense of feelings • Acting as a mirror to work through feelings • Providing a safe space	• Misreading the context & guiding incorrectly • Fuelling unhelpful or destructive emotions
 Relational agency: The ability to create, sustain, nurture connections with other people	• Providing low-stakes prep before convos • Helping develop personal identity	• Encouraging or driving isolation from others • Driving conformity & homogeneity
 Structural agency: The ability to navigate and shape systems or collective norms — you & your voice matter	• Translating esoteric systems into navigable information • Connecting individuals to the right resources, people, or next steps	• Providing inaccurate information • Creating standardized ways to think & eroding individual voice

2) Input Agency

We started this research focused on how AI interactions impacted human agency — but we quickly observed that **people who used AI for the same task would often have vastly different experiences**. For example, when using AI to draft emails, some people found it helped them be more efficient, while others found themselves stuck in frustrating back-and-forth exchanges.

This is because **people are not blank slates**, they arrive at AI interactions with pre-existing skills, resources, blindspots, and anxieties — they bring different levels of **Input Agency**.

We observed two key dimensions that explain how people approach AI, which defined **four profiles of users**, each with their own distinct **motivations, challenges, and payoffs from using AI**.

Industry efforts to improve AI largely focus on the outputs of AI interactions (e.g. efficiency, dependency, AI slop), **overlooking a critical opportunity to better understand and address people with different input agency profiles**.

The world feels dependable

I trust that systems, people, or norms will respond predictably

Uncertain in myself

I question my abilities, value(s), or direction

Structured Dependents

AI as a shortcut for low-confidence tasks

Empowered Navigators

AI as a well-placed tool, not a crutch

Conviction in myself

I have clarity about who I am & what matters to me

Silver Bullet Thinkers

AI as an all-purpose “hail mary” solution

Adaptive Optimizers

AI as the “it factor” in seeking perfection

The world feels chaotic

I cannot count on the world because it is unpredictable, unstable, or unsafe

Those facing instability (**Silver Bullet Thinkers** and **Adaptive Optimizers**) feel the biggest agency payoff from AI because, in **their quest for security, their needs are immediate, intense, and boundless** — needs that AI is well-suited to meet in an on-demand, personalized chat interface.

3) The Agency Loop

Advancing **The 5 Agencies** consistently gives users self-confidence and helps them navigate the world, which may strengthen their **Input Agency** over time. Building for a **Positive Agency Loop** is the way to help users **achieve more sustained and substantial agency payoffs**.

Note that the **Agency Loop** can be a **virtuous or vicious cycle**. Prolonged undermining of users' agencies may also lead to further disempowerment.

Using prototypes and mocks, we tested some early hypotheses about ways to improve agency.

🔍 Early insights from prototypes in the field:

We heard that people felt a loss of agency when they 'got stuck in gear' with AI, and worried about the implications of their AI use for their long-term mental agility.

We hypothesized that helping people engage more critically and be more aware of their AI use could strengthen feelings of agency when using AI.

We tested two custom versions of Gemini: (1) one that encouraged metacognition, and (2) one that challenged users to explore their ideas using the Socratic method.

We found pushback that felt like it was making users dig deeper to **become a better AI prompter** was welcome. Pushback that tried to get a user to step back or away from AI **felt judgemental and made users feel undermined**.